

PREFACE

You must pardon me for I am a rank impostor in the realm of Urdu poetry – with about 18 months of learning for about 15 minutes a day – and here I am with the audacity to release a book on the same.

The prime accused for this high crime and misdemeanor is my publisher Dr. Amir Ullah Khan, an economist/consultant from Hyderabad and an accomplished student of Urdu, who convinced me the charm of a book like this is exactly that: a novice filled with *mohabbat* for the Urdu *sher*, making it accessible to other unschooled *aashiqs* (lovers) just like him.

Well, who am I to argue with an *Urdu ustad*! And this is how you find yourself reading this *Alfaaz ki Mehfil* with its uniqueness: a total lack of either erudition or scholarship, typically the hallmark of any book.

Alfaaz ki Mehfil is the faltering journey of an enthusiastic learner, presented with all its faults, warts and imperfect edges.

This *mohabbat* for Urdu got lit fortuitously during Covid confinement when my wife, Sangeeta, and I happened to catch an Urdu sitcom *Taana Baana* on YouTube. The ring of Urdu, just like that of Italian, sounded like music to my ears. I started to learn a few words a day. Soon, I realized that there is a better way: translate Urdu couplets into English and learn the words as part of that process.

And, *mashaallah*, did I hit a gold mine! The Urdu *sher*, I realized, is revealing, enriching, transformative, life-changing.

In many languages and cultures, poets devoted their intellect and creative energies to praise or appeal to the divine, portray

royal fiction, translate mythological epics, or in appreciation of nature, mostly.

Not so in Urdu poetry. Mostly agnostic, largely progressive, predominantly secular, unabashedly loving, innately rebellious, Urdu poets captured the essence of life with all its yearnings, enthusiasms, ecstasies, pathos, pains, struggles, trials, triumphs, and, flowing from all the above, transcendent wisdom.

Urdu poets observed life and captured the feelings and principles that hold true across time and space, both within ourselves and without. They had, for example, more interest in the relaxing, revealing power of a drink than in the imagined comfort of the divine.

Urdu poetry also emerged as the voice of revolt against religious orthodoxy, fundamentalism, injustice, despotism, and tyranny. It powered the Indian freedom movement and then turned its ire against oppression and authoritarianism.

The compelling beauty of the *sher* is that the poet's learning of a lifetime is distilled and compressed into two short lines, expressed in supremely evocative and rich Urdu, a language synthesized from four remarkable languages: Khariboli (Hindustani), Persian, Sanskrit, and Arabic.

As a student of Zen Buddhism and Stoicism, I found particular resonance with and striking parallels in Urdu poetry for two reasons: one, no axiomatic beliefs (such as God, soul, karma); two, observing life as is and figuring out how to make the best of it.

So, still investing my 15 minutes a day, I have been inflicting the translations of select couplets on my helpless hostages who suffered with a smile and encouraged me nevertheless: my wife, kids, family and friends, especially in RT84, my NIT, Trichy alumni group.